



MINDFULNESS ON THE MATS™

The Warrior's Edge

Parent & Student Handout

What is Mindfulness on the Mats™?

You might hear the word “mindfulness” and think of yoga studios or sitting quietly in a room. However, mindfulness is not new to the martial arts. Mindfulness on the Mats™ (MOTM) is a holistic curriculum designed to help martial artists and athletes improve their mental game. It teaches students how to use quality mindfulness instruction to support their growth and performance in the dojo.

Why Bring Mindfulness to the Dojo?

Performance

Just as you notice when you overextend a physical strike, mindfulness helps you notice when your mind overextends and pulls you off center.

Awareness (Zanshin)

We train to notice what is happening inside us and outside us. Failure to pay attention can mean defeat.

Emotional Control

Breathing and mental focus tools help students ground themselves when they feel angry, hyper, hurt, or frustrated.

Science-Backed

Research shows that mindfulness can literally change brain activity and structure — strengthening the decision-making center and calming the panic response.

The Four Pillars of the Mindful Warrior

Pillar I

BREATH

Breathing is the keystone of focus and energy. By synchronizing breath with movement, students increase their power and ability to remain calm under pressure.

Pillar II

BODY

We practice scanning for tension and ensuring our physical structure is aligned and grounded — because martial artists must know where every part of their body is in space.

Pillar III

MIND

We explore Mushin (“No Mind”), a state where the mind is not fixated on one thought or fear. This flexibility allows the warrior to react instantly.

Pillar IV

SPIRIT

This module focuses on the state of “flow” — when the rest of the world disappears and you are totally present in the here and now, moving with intuition.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Is this religious?

No. While aspects of mindfulness originate from ancient Buddhist practices, these techniques are used today in entirely secular settings: schools, the military, veterans programs, and corporate boardrooms. There is no religious content in this curriculum.

Q: Is this therapy?

No. The MOTM curriculum is educational in nature only. While mindfulness has therapeutic effects, this program is designed for coaching and performance, not psychotherapy.

Printed copies of this handout are available at the front desk.